

The use of dental radiographs: update and recommendations.

BACKGROUND AND OVERVIEW: The National Council on Radiation Protection & Measurements updated its recommendations on radiation protection in dentistry in 2003, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention published its Guidelines for Infection Control in Dental Health-Care Settings in 2003, and the U.S. Food and Drug Administration updated its selection criteria for dental radiographs in 2004. This report summarizes the recommendations presented in these documents and addresses additional topics such as patient selection criteria, film selection for conventional radiographs, collimation, beam filtration, patient protective equipment, film holders, operator protection, film exposure and processing, infection control, quality assurance, image viewing, direct digital radiography and continuing education of dental health care workers who expose radiographs. **CONCLUSIONS:** This report discusses implementation of proper radiographic practices. In addition to these guidelines, dentists should be aware of, and comply with, applicable federal and state regulations. **CLINICAL IMPLICATIONS:** Dentists should weigh the benefits of dental radiographs against the consequences of increasing a patient's exposure to radiation and implement appropriate radiation control procedures.